

St. Joseph the All Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

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Note: With God helping us, we will send a newsletter on at least the first and the 15th of each month to all those we minister to in prison. This is the 5th, sent to **69** souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need something along these lines.

Catechetical Letter 2

Who is Man? Why was He created? What are the implications?

In our first letter, we addressed the fundamental fact of the universe - God. All life, all blessedness, all goodness, all knowledge comes from Him.

Now we will address essential Scripture about man in the Bible. Most of the Bible is directly related to man since he is the crown of God's creation. The earliest reference to man is the most important because it teaches us if we look at it with spiritual eyes, when, how, and why we were created. All these things lead to the most crucial dogma we must know about ourselves and God - the implications of our creation by God -- that is, **how should we live?**

The goal of everything in Christianity is the fulfillment of the implications of this first event in the history of humankind:

And God said, Let us make man according to our image and likeness, and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the flying creatures of heaven, and over the cattle and all the earth, and over all the reptiles that creep on the earth. (27) And God made man, according to the image of God he made him, male and female he made them. Genesis 1:26-27

Man was created on the 6th day of creation, as the last created being. The angels were already created, and all the animals, from the fish to the reptiles and birds and mammals. Man was made last because he is the crown of God's creation.

He is the most important created being. It is essential to understand why.

First, we ask the question: **"Why did God create man?"** There is a simple one-word answer: love. God created man because of love. To understand this answer, we must understand love. We will never learn about it from popular songs and entertainment. We can only know of love from God, that is, *from our experience of God. Everything we do* must be to increase our experience of God, and if we experience God with a soul that is prepared, we know God.

The scriptures state the "God is love"; this means that love is an eternal attribute of God since God is eternal. Furthermore, a fundamental property of love is that it always has an object. Love gives of itself to another. Another fundamental aspect of love is that it communicates with another. We experience this daily in our lives, even though the way we love and are loved is usually far from perfect (that is, we do not love, as God loves). If love is eternal and has an object, Who does God "give Himself" to and communicate with?

God always has and will always love Himself. The Father loves the Son and the Spirit. The Son loves the Father and the Spirit. The Spirit loves the Father and the Son. The three persons of God, each fully God since they are of one essence, equally love each other, with one perfect united will, purpose, and intelligence.

Let us look carefully at the meaning of "image" and "likeness." It is critical to understand these words because *our life's entire direction must be based on our understanding of them.*

The Scripture tells us a curious thing: It has God referring to Himself in the plural when He says, **"... Let us make man ..."**. This is the second reference to God as a Trinity in the Scripture. (See the Bibliography for the first reference) This is a critical point because immediately after referring to Himself as a Trinity of co-equal persons, He creates man by His word in His IMAGE and likeness.

In daily life, we understand "image" to be a similarity. We admire a baby and say, "he is the spitting image of his father!" And indeed, we are made in the image of our human parents. We share in their attributes - color of their eyes, intelligence, athletic or musical ability, and many other things. We came from them, so we are similar to them.

What does it mean to be made in the "image" of God? We do not share in the color of God's eyes or any human physical attribute since God is above all created things and is wholly immaterial. How are we like God, that is, as intelligent creatures made by God, which of God's attributes do we share with Him in some way?

The Church understands that there three attributes of God which humans share. God has perfect **knowledge** of all things, perfect **desire** of only good things, and a perfect **will** to accomplish whatever He wants. These fundamental attributes are also imparted to man. In God, all these attributes are perfectly expressed, but they are present in a germinal form in man. We can understand this by thinking of a child. This child may have inherited the intelligence of his parents. Still, if he is never read to, or even spoken to, or given education and primary care, he will not express this intelligence to an ultimate degree. So it is with our God-given attributes.

We are given the capacity to have perfect **knowledge**. Since God is perfect and all good things come from Him, the ultimate expression of this capacity is God's perfect knowledge, that is knowing God, by sharing in His inner life.

We are given the capacity to **desire**. In ascetical writings, this is called the "incensive power" of the soul. We can desire good or evil things, but only desiring good things will fully develop this capacity to be in agreement with God, Who only and always desires good.

We are given the capacity to accomplish the things we desire. This can also be called **"will."** Our will must be exercised to become healthy. God's will is perfect. He can accomplish whatever He desires. Our will is weak and must be perfected through effort so that we can perfectly accomplish good always.

A Short Bibliography: Scripture/other writings about the creation of man and the image and likeness of God.

In the beginning, God made the heaven and the earth. (2) But the earth was unsightly and unfurnished, and darkness was over the deep, and the Spirit of God moved over the water. (3) And God said, Let there be light, and there was light. Genesis 1:1-3

This is the first reference to God as a Trinity of persons. "God" refers to the Father. The reference to the Holy Spirit is obvious. The Son of God, Who is called the "Word" in Scripture, is referred to by the statement, "God said."

God created man of the earth, and made him after His image. (2) And he turned him into it again, and clothed him

with strength according to himself. (3) He gave him the number of his days and time, and gave him power over all things that are upon the earth. (4) He put the fear of him upon all flesh, and he had dominion over beasts and fowls. (5) He created of him a helpmate like to himself, he gave them counsel, and a tongue, and eyes, and ears, and a heart to devise: and he filled them with the knowledge of understanding. (6) He created in them the science of the spirit, he fired their heart with wisdom, and shewed them both good and evil. (7) He set his eye upon their hearts to shew them the greatness of his works: (8) That they might praise the name which he hath sanctified: and glory in his wondrous act that they might declare the glorious things of his

works. (9) Moreover, he gave them instructions, and the law of life for an inheritance. (10) He made an everlasting covenant with them, and he shewed them his justice and judgments.

Wisdom of Sirach 17:1-10

"I was born to love people. It doesn't concern me if he is a Turk, black, or white. I see in the face of each person the image of God. And for this image of God, I am willing to sacrifice everything." — Elder Amphilochios Makris of Patmos

So, being made of dust from the earth, and having received a breath of life which the word calls an intelligent soul and the image of God, he was placed in the garden to work and given a commandment to keep. How so? So that, as long as he did keep it and work, he would remain immortal and compete everlastingly with the angels, and together with them would praise God unceasingly and receive His illumination and see God intelligibly, and hear His divine voice. But in that same hour that he should transgress the commandment given him and eat of the tree from which God had commanded him not to eat, he would be given over to death and be deprived of the eyes of his soul. He would be stripped of his robe of divine glory; his ears would be stopped up, and he would fall from his way of life with the angels and be chased out of paradise. This indeed did happen to the transgressor, and he fell from his eternal and

Priest Seraphim Holland 2015,2020

[St Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney, Texas](http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechetical-letter-02-2015+image-and-likeness.html)

This article is at <http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechetical-letter-02-2015+image-and-likeness.html> (PDF and Word Versions also Available)

Prison ministry news

We are sending this newsletter to 69 people. The cost is approximately \$1.10 per newsletter sent. Of course, we send the newsletter quite willingly to anyone in prison who wishes it and benefits from it for free. If you have family or loved ones that want to receive the letter, or anyone else you think would benefit who's in the so-called free world (but you know what we think about that: the only time you are in the free world is when your soul is free from passions), please ask them if they can afford to send a \$25 donation to the prison ministry for years' worth of newsletters, along with their postal address. That is the bare minimum of our costs. Anybody can contact us by email or postal address and ask how to donate. All of our contact information is above.

Please tell us when your prison begins to allow ministry visits. As far as we know, no visitors are allowed. We would hope that the chaplains would contact us, but you are probably a more reliable source.

Regarding the property in Marshall, just like it is in prison, life has gone on and has been complicated. We are committed to buying the property, but there are some technical issues that we must deal with, and unfortunately, there's been pressing concerns that Jude/Thaddeus had to take care of in Marshall, and he's not been able to talk to certain people. We are sorry that we don't have more news for you.

What does it mean not to lie?

What does it mean not to lie? It doesn't mean going around preaching the truth at the top of your voice (perish the thought!). It doesn't even mean muttering what you think in an undertone. It simply means: not saying what you don't think, and that includes not whispering, not opening your mouth, not raising your hand, not casting your vote, not feigning a smile, not lending your presence, not standing up, and not cheering.

...This path is the safest and most accessible of all the paths open to us for the average man on the street. But it is also the most effective! Only we, knowing our system, can imagine what will happen when thousands and tens of thousands of people take this

path - our nation will be purified and transformed without shots or bloodshed.

But this path is also the most moral: we shall be commencing this liberation and purification in our own souls! Before we purify the country, we shall have purified ourselves. And this is the only correct historical order: for what is the good of purifying our country's air if we ourselves remain dirty?

Alexander Solzhenitsyn, in "The Smatterers," _From Under the Rubble_, with Mikhail Agursky, A.B.Evgeny Barabanov, Vadim Borisov, F. Korsakov, and Igor Shafarevich, 1974. Pages 276-7 in the 1981 Gateway Edition

A word from Fr David

Prayers and Bible Studies with the Non-Orthodox

Three of our Orthodox brothers wrote the following questions to me over the past few weeks:

Question: [After describing some inmates who treat others badly and then turn around and hold Bible studies in the Faith Dorm]: "I find myself very distant and unwelcoming. Speaking of, in this dorm, there are all kinds of faiths. What is your advice on Bible studies with other faiths - say, Protestant, Catholic, Mormon, etc. Currently, I listen but do not participate from my rack- same thing with prayer circles. I try to be polite and pray in my rack when they pray, just not in the circle."

Question: "I'm the only Orthodox in my dorm. The other Christians get together and have Bible studies. Me being a Christian myself, I feel I need to participate in Bible studies, but when I do, I have to listen to all the crazy beliefs they have been taught, and if I open my mouth, it could start a debate, which leads to arguments. But if I keep my mouth shut, what am I getting out of the Bible study anyway? Should I not even go at all?"

Question: "I'm writing to ask about praying with the non-Orthodox. When I refuse, my witness is zilch. To spread the Gospel, we must evangelize, correct? And to evangelize, we must preach to, pray for, and provide a good witness to non-Orthodox; otherwise, there would be no Orthodox. For example, when you were converting me (or bearing witness to Christ with me), you had to pray with me, who was not Orthodox at that time. Could you please explain this more to me?"

I will start by explaining the underlying reasoning and principles which guide our interactions with Non-Orthodox Christians. Then I will offer certain practical suggestions for your fellowship with them.

You are right to avoid participating in Bible studies, prayer circles, etc., outside of the Orthodox Church, where, may God forgive and enlighten them, many confused people utter falsehoods, even blasphemies, in their ignorance of the true Faith (Calvinism is blasphemy, for instance, by making God the author of evil and sole architect of man's damnation). By your participation, you can unintentionally imply that we Orthodox are in union and general agreement with other Christians outside the Church. This is not a good witness if we desire them to seek out and enter the Ark of the Orthodox Church to pass safely through the sea of life. We may lead them to think: If my boat is just as seaworthy, why climb aboard your Ark? If Orthodoxy is just another flavor at the spiritual "Baskin Robbins," isn't it all a matter of "taste"? As St. Paisios would say, our life as an Orthodox Christian should give others around us "a good kind of uneasiness" that leads them to question their manner of life and beliefs.

For this to happen, it must be apparent that there is a difference between Orthodoxy (right worship/belief) and heterodoxy (departure from it). If, with peace and goodwill, you don't participate in these prayer circles and Bible studies, your quiet example may lead to good questions from others who notice your absence. They will see you living a Christian life (the most inspiring Gospel message you can preach). It can also be disturbing to your

soul, stirring up confusion or anger, to hear and see all the conflicting versions of biblical interpretation, "prophecies," displays of "spiritual gifts," etc., which often pop up at these gatherings and present a hundred avenues leading away from the teachings of the Orthodox Faith.

It is better to spend your time drawing closer to Christ through peaceful prayer and spiritual reading, not burdened by the impossible task of convincing or changing others around you who are often quite set in their ways and desire to be teachers of men. As you are transformed through repentance and humble love for God, you will be given the grace necessary to help others around you; and the more you love your neighbor in word and deed, the more your neighbor will see Christ in you and voluntarily ask to understand the Orthodox Faith which guides you. This approach is confirmed by Elder Cleopa of Romania, a great confessor, teacher, and spiritual father of the 20th century, who strictly forbade Orthodox Christians to attend prayer services and Bible studies lead by non-Orthodox groups.

Take as an example: the silence, humility, and meekness of Christ as He was interrogated, judged, and condemned. Pilate and the Jews all marveled that He kept His peace and did not seek to defend Himself or convince others of their errors: and in this, the Truth and certainty of His Word was established more powerfully than by any arguments. Seeing that they were not desirous of knowing the truth but were convinced of their own opinion, our Savior bore His Cross silently and endured to the end. And how did He convince the centurion St. Longinus (whom we commemorated a few days ago), who stood at the foot of the Cross, of His Godhead and Glory? By His humble, all-forgiving love for His enemies and friends. This centurion was convicted by the Truth Who hung upon the Cross before Him and confessed, "Truly this was the Son of God." (Matt. 27:54)

Another example: St. Paul would preach the Gospel to Jews and Gentiles alike, but if their hearts hardened and they resisted or fought against him, he would depart to another place. (See Acts 9:23-30; Acts 13:42-52; Acts 14:4-7, 19-20; to name a few examples). Spiritual seed can only take root in the soft soil of humble inquiry, not in the hardened earth of self-will and self-assurance.

Be kind to others, condemn no man, see your own sinfulness, keep your attention on your inner world, preserve your peace, and pray the Jesus Prayer in your heart or quietly to yourself during these times. If you wish to go to the chapel for a break during a service, sit respectfully, don't participate, and pray the Jesus Prayer or read. You should also pray that God would guide the souls of those men to the full knowledge and love of Christ and of His Holy Church! If God grants that someone approaches you with a sincere interest in the Orthodox Faith and a desire to discuss it, then asking God to grant you wisdom, you can answer with a clear conscience and undisturbed heart. By comparison, arguments rob us of peace and blind our spiritual eyes so that we can't see the image of Christ in our neighbor. You know this from experience, and I say this only by way of reminder.

We Orthodox, possessors (though not yet full practitioners - Lord, help us!) of the fullness of the Christian faith in Jesus Christ as

members of His Body the Church - we Orthodox must **lead**, not **be lead**, by others outside the Church who, to one degree or another, are walking astray. Instead, we look to the Lord, the Saints, the Holy Fathers and Mothers, and our Bishop and Priest, for spiritual guidance and leadership.

Now that you have the Typika Service available to you every week, this is an opportunity to invite your Orthodox brothers (if you can see them) and sincere non-Orthodox inquirers to attend: this involves you as Orthodox men practicing and imparting the Faith to inquirers, and not they imparting their beliefs to you. If they are peaceable and well-intentioned, seeking Christ humbly in their hearts, you could also lead a simple Bible or spiritual book study with them in attendance, leaning on the commentaries and teachings of the Holy Fathers and not making it up as you go; when difficult questions arise, simply respond, "Let me get the right answer for you from my priest," and refer these to Fr. Seraphim or myself by mail.

The commentary in the Orthodox Study Bible provides a good foundation for discussion, and I'll be sending in more commentary books in the near future that you could use. Be sure you write to me or Fr. Seraphim before starting a study group and ask a blessing and guidance for your efforts.

As an example of this "lived evangelism" in practice: one of our Orthodox brothers at Montgomery County Jail was recently going about his Orthodox life, striving imperfectly but sincerely to maintain daily prayers, fasting, the offering of the Typika Service on Sundays, and feasts, etc., and by God's grace there were soon five inquirers coming to Typika with him! One of them wrote to me, and we stay in contact. I think this is a good model for Orthodox Christian outreach in prison.

May God bless your spiritual labors and evangelism! May He enlighten the darkness of all who languish in prison, granting them the assurance of His mercy and drawing them to Himself! With love in the Lord, Fr. David

A Word from St. Paisios for This Time of Lockdown & Separation - with thoughts from Fr. David

A nun asked the elder, - Geronda ('elder' in Greek) does God help more at the beginning of the spiritual struggle?

St Paisios: Yes, in the first steps of the spiritual life man receives much help from God, just as parents protect their children when they are small. As the children grow, they are not protected as much because they begin to use their brains. At the beginning of his struggle, man is more aware of the Grace of God. Later God will allow him to struggle and mature on his own. I planted some tomatoes. At first, I watered them every day; after that, I left them for a while. When their leaves started to turn yellow, then I watered them. As long as they were not watered, they were forced to send their roots deep to find moisture in the ground; it was during this same time that they produced the first green fruits. If I had watered them continuously, they would have only grown tall, and their roots would have remained near the surface.

Fr. David: During this time of hardship when our fellowship is restricted, and we cannot pray, receive the Sacraments, and study together in person, I hope in the mercy of God that all of you will put down deeper roots in your daily prayers and Typika service use, fasting, a careful reading of the Orthodox Study Bible, an examination of Orthodox spiritual books and the newsletter, and practice of the Gospel commandments in relation to your neighbors. Then your souls will ripen and bear fruit, and perhaps my spiritual hunger and poverty will be met by your spiritual bounty. God help and save us!

Martyr Longinus the Centurion, who stood at the Cross of the Lord

The Holy Martyr Longinus the Centurion (Commemorated on October 16 OS / 29 NS), a Roman soldier, served in Judea under the Governor's command, Pontius Pilate. When our Savior Jesus Christ was crucified, it was the detachment of soldiers under Longinus's command, which stood watch on Golgotha, at the very foot of the Holy Cross. Longinus and his soldiers were eyewitnesses of the final moments of the earthly life of the Lord, and of the great and awesome portents that appeared at His death. These events shook the centurion's soul. Longinus believed in Christ and confessed before everyone, "Truly this was the Son of God" (Mt. 27:54).

According to Church Tradition, Longinus was the soldier who pierced the side of the Crucified Savior with a spear and received healing from an eye affliction when blood and water poured forth from the wound.

After the Crucifixion and Burial of the Savior, Longinus stood watch with his company at the Sepulchre of the Lord. These soldiers were present at the All-Radiant Resurrection of Christ. The Jews bribed them to lie and say that His disciples had stolen away the Body of Christ, but Longinus and two of his comrades refused to be seduced by the Jewish gold. They also refused to remain silent about the miracle of the Resurrection.

Having come to believe in the Savior, the soldiers received Baptism from the apostles and decided to leave military service. Saint Longinus left Judea to preach about Jesus Christ the Son of God in his native land (Cappadocia), and his two comrades followed him.

The fiery words of those who had participated in the great events in Judea swayed the hearts and minds of the Cappadocians; Christianity began quickly to spread throughout the city and the surrounding villages. When they learned of this, the Jewish elders persuaded Pilate to send a company of soldiers to Cappadocia to kill Longinus and his comrades. When the soldiers arrived at Longinus's village, the former centurion himself came out to meet the soldiers



and took them to his home. After a meal, the soldiers revealed their visit's purpose, not knowing that the master of the house was the very man they were seeking. Then Longinus and his friends identified themselves and told the startled soldiers to carry out their duty.

The soldiers wanted to let the saints go and advised them to flee, but they refused to do this, showing their firm intention to suffer for Christ. The holy martyrs were beheaded, and their bodies were buried at the place where the saints were martyred. The head of Saint Longinus, however, was sent to Pilate.

Pilate gave orders to cast the martyr's head on a trash-heap outside the city walls. After a while, a certain blind widow from Cappadocia arrived in Jerusalem with her son to pray at the holy places and to ask that her sight be restored. After becoming blind, she had sought the help of physicians to cure her, but all their efforts were in vain.

The woman's son became ill shortly after reaching Jerusalem, and he died a few days later. The widow grieved for the loss of her son, who had served as her guide.

Saint Longinus appeared to her in a dream and comforted her. He told her that she would see her son in heavenly glory and also receive her sight. He told her to go outside the city walls, and there she would find his head in a great pile of refuse. Guides led the

blind woman to the rubbish heap, and she began to dig with her hands. As soon as she touched the martyr's head, the woman received her sight, and she glorified God and Saint Longinus.

Taking up the head, she brought it to the place she was staying and washed it. The next night, Saint Longinus appeared to her again, this time with her son. A bright light surrounded them, and Saint Longinus said, "Woman, behold the son for whom you grieve. See what glory and honor are his now, and be consoled. God has numbered him with those in His heavenly Kingdom. Now take my head and your son's body, and bury them in the same casket. Do not weep for your son, for he will rejoice forever in great glory and happiness."

The woman carried out the saint's instructions and returned to her home in Cappadocia. There she buried her son and the head of Saint Longinus. Once, she had been overcome by grief for her son, but her weeping was transformed into joy when she saw him with Saint Longinus. She had sought healing for her eyes, and also received healing of her soul.

A Word from Fr. Seraphim

We must encounter everything spiritually!

I just recently celebrated a funeral for a very dear friend. When serving the multiple funeral services for +Paul, I was in a *sensitive spiritual state*. This happens when something in our life touches us in some way; this is the most critical time to pray. This should happen to all of us who pray at a funeral for a friend, but it should happen much more frequently than that. If you are not in a spiritual sensitive spiritual state almost daily, you have some changes to make!

Things are happening in your daily life that should cause reverberations in your soul. The Scripture speaks of meditating on the law of God, especially in Psalm 118, where all 176 verses describe the law of God. Have you wondered what meditation on the law of God is? Everything that happens in your life has a spiritual significance, and you must respond spiritually. It is not that you just sit somewhere and look at your navel and think about things.

I want to tell you about things that reverberated in my soul during the funeral service. Please apply this to **everything** that happens in your life. Everything that happens around us is spiritual if we



live

spiritually. Your life experiences, the people you meet, and the people you get along with and with whom you do not get along, Scripture that you read, and observations that you make all, and everything else should be understood spiritually.

Why pray for the reposed to have "rest" and the living to have "peace"?

Our services for the dead include many petitions asking for "rest," and we have many prayers for the living that ask for peace. The prayer below is one that the priest says at the end of petitions for the dead. I may be a bit of a maverick, but I recommend that you also say this prayer for your loved ones. Some people say that laypeople should never say a priest's prayers in the service, but this prayer is very similar to other prayers that lay people say, and it is my favorite prayer for the dead because I say it every day.

*O God of spirits and of all flesh, Who hast trampled down death, and overthrown the devil, and given life to Thy world: Do Thou, Thyself, O Lord **give rest** to the soul(s) of Thy departed servant(s) _____,*

In a place of light, a place of green pasture, a place of repose, whence all sickness, sorrow, and sighing are fled away. Pardon every sin committed by him (**her, them**), in word, deed or thought, in that Thou art a good God, the Lover of mankind; For there is no man that liveth and sinneth not, for Thou alone art without sin, Thy righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, and Thy Word is Truth.

For Thou art the Resurrection, and the Life, and the repose of Thy departed servant(s) _____,

O Christ our God, and to Thee we send up glory, together with Thine unoriginate Father, and Thy most holy and good and life-creating Spirit, now and ever, and to the ages of ages. Amen.

Have you ever wondered why we ask for rest for the departed and peace for ourselves? Does it resonate in your soul that so many things we do in our daily life do not give us rest? We are not at peace. We do things, think things, we "are" things that are not peaceful. The Church is not asking for physical rest; she is talking about the soul being serene and calm. Do you know what this calmness consists of? It is when the soul is not troubled by sinful desires or thoughts and is wholly filled with God's light. It has nothing to do with the physical circumstances of your life.

Have you ever been out in the morning by a lake, and the water is entirely like glass? Isn't it beautiful and very peaceful? That peace is disturbed if you throw a rock into the water. Or you see a stream, and it's clear, but as soon as you walk in it, dirt from the bottom makes the water muddy and turbulent and unclear; you cannot see through the water anymore. That is the condition of our souls.

When we ask for "rest" for our departed loved ones, we are asking that their souls would be filled with still water; we are asking for peace in their souls. We are asking that they would not be filled with any darkness or turbulent thoughts, but only with the light of God.

If we ask for these things for the departed and peace for ourselves, does it not stand to reason that we should also live in such a way that we obtain peace? Or are we asking for something and expecting God to supply it by some sort of magic, without our effort, and our sweat, and our blood?

Now we have a political process going on that cannot be described by either peace or rest. People are getting all excited about it; perhaps terrible things will happen to our country soon, but horrible things have happened in the past. We have to be able to negotiate these kinds of things in our daily life and maintain peace in our souls.

Whether we are late to work or someone cuts us off in traffic, or someone mistreats us and we have no recourse, we must have rest in our souls. This is possible only if we have the experience of God by living spiritually. The spiritual man is not angry because of the things that he encounters, but only sees God and loves Him, and always feels a great blessing of being His child.

When we are asking for rest, that is what they are asking for. We are asking God would be present in our life, and that would we would see Him and feel Him. Implicit in this request is that we would firmly decide only to do things (which includes the things we think and the attitudes we have) that enable us to have this peace. You should be trying to do things that bring you to that state and not do the things that bring you to an unrestful state. Those are things like arguing, having the last word, and the extra donut we know will make us feel sluggish for the rest of the day. But the things that are less obvious include laziness and skipping our prayers, and general lethargy.

Two primary ways in which we obtain rest are prayer and controlling our thoughts. Each one positively influences the other, and of course, if we have bad thoughts, we cannot pray, even if we think we are praying. Most of our bad thoughts or because we don't like something. We don't like how we are treated, our environment, or what people say about us. We are like three-year-olds who do not want to be told what to do. This is why obedience is the only way that leads to peace. The following quote illustrates the kind of obedience we should seek.

In the Evergetinos, we read that Abba Nistheron had become renowned as a holy man. Once when they asked him what he had accomplished in his life, he answered, "I, my fathers, have neither virtue nor have I practiced any good work. When I entered the monastery, I made a decision and said, 'I and the jackass are one Elder Joseph of Vatopaidi, "Obedience is Life," Elder Ephraim of Katounakia, pp 06-107

Whatever it is, live more spiritually, and then you will have more rest. May God help us to gain rest in all things.

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life:6,7

From "A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life," Hieroconfessor Alexander (Orlov) Of Omsk, who fell asleep in 1977 at the age of 99, translated by Protopresbyter Thomas Marretta. These gems of spiritual wisdom are sent in email messages from my good friend, Fr Demetrios Carellas. We will investigate getting copies of this book to send to many of you. (Priest Seraphim)

6. If the enemy robs you of attention and compunction during prayer, do not desist. He who forces himself to pray when his soul is dry stands higher than the man who prays with tears.

7. Your mind and heart should be intimate with the New Testament. Study the New Testament constantly. Do not invent your own interpretation of it, but learn its meaning from the Holy Fathers and from your own spiritual father.

Catechetical Letter: The Four Bows

The following is a significantly edited transcription of a short homily: http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/orthopraxis_2010+the-four-bows.mp3

The Holy Fathers call prayer the "science of sciences." Prayer is a cooperative venture between man and God. Only God can purify the soul, but man must order his life in such a way that he is prepared for God to enter the soul. Therefore it is impossible to pray without effort, and living our life spiritually, and fighting sin, and establishing a rule of prayer. The Apostle Paul tells us to "pray without ceasing," but most of us know that we do not come even close to this. The person who prays without ceasing does not need to prepare himself for prayer since he is always praying. ***We must prepare ourselves for prayer.***

The four bows" is a way to prepare ourselves for prayer, and if we are honest with ourselves, it is sometimes the only prayer that we might say in any kind of formal way in the morning.

The four bows were originally an article in a publication called Nicodemus. This article was the teaching of a bishop who would teach children how to pray, and it applies to us. It applies to us is, if we are honest with ourselves, we would know that we often do not pray as we should, and we often allow things to get in the way of prayer. Whether it be oversleeping or something we have to do before we have to go to work or laziness or just the hustle of the day, we don't say our morning prayers at all, or we don't say them completely, or we don't say them with attention. Generally, if you don't pray in the morning, the day doesn't go as well as it could.

This applies to all of us because it is something simple that takes less than a minute. It doesn't take a book. It just takes a little bit of time and focus.

Before anything else, when you get up in the morning, before brushing your teeth or getting a drink of water, do the "Four Bows." Stand by your icon corner (you should have an icon corner or an icon or an icon or two in someplace that is easy to get to) or a cross on the wall, and do four bows or *poklans* (that is the Russian word for "bow").

A bow is when you make the sign of the cross and as you do this, bow deeply, with your hand touching or coming close to the ground. You could also do a prostration. A prostration is: as you make the sign of the cross prostrate to the ground (get on your knees and bring your head on or close to the ground) and come back up. Either one is acceptable. I recommend that you try to do prostrations because they warm up the body and the soul, and they help keep us from being lazy, but if you're "creaky" in the morning, at least do the bows. Each bow (prostration) is for a particular prayer.

"Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner."

"Most Holy Theotokos, save us."

"St. Seraphim pray to God for me." (put the name of your patron saint here, or any favorite saint)

"Holy Angel of God, my guardian, pray unto God for me."

This is the perfect time to begin the rest of your prayers, but, things as they are, you might have something to do, you might have to wake up the kids or whatever, but at least, if you do not go back to your prayers in the morning, you have at least begun the day giving your first fruits to God.

You could, if you're zealous, do more bows because you have many favorite saints who you want to pray to, or you may want to do a prostration or a bow for each person in your family and people very close to you (highly recommended!).

This very small rule is an application of a fundamental principle that I want you to tattoo on your forehead and look at it whenever you are lazy or despondent or feeling inadequate because you just don't do enough. ***"It is better to do a little thing then not do a big thing."***

Let this be your small rule for the beginning, and then, if you pray more later, that is good. But if your day takes on a life of its own, as our days often do, then at least you will have offered a prayer to God in the beginning. So let it be just four bows, and then if you say your morning rule, fine, but if you make it into ten bows or twelve bows or 50 bows, there will be many days when you'll think, "Oh, I just can't do 50 bows," and you won't do it at all. But you can do four bows. It doesn't take long at all, maybe 30 seconds. Please, begin saying the "Four Bows" when you get up in the morning.

This is perfect for children because they love things that involve motion and activity. When they get up, say, "Let's do the four bows together," and TEACH (by EXAMPLE) your children to give the first part of their day, the best part of their day, to God. every day

Priest Seraphim Holland

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/orthopraxis_2010+the-four-bows.mp3

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